

After Twenty Years



INTRODUCTION

BRIEF BIOGRAPHY OF O. HENRY

Born on September 11, 1862, in Greensboro, North Carolina, O. Henry was a popular American writer of short fiction. In his younger years, William Sydney Porter lived in Austin, Texas, working a variety of odd jobs such as being a sheep rancher, pharmacist, and bank teller. During this time, he led an active social life and was famous for his wit, storytelling, and even singing. He also was an avid reader and wrote consistently, which his wife, Athol Estes, encouraged him to pursue professionally. This prompted him to become a successful writer for the *Rolling Stone* and later columnist and cartoonist for the *Houston Post*. However, in 1898 he was indicted and arrested for embezzlement—which took place during his time as a bank teller—and sentenced to 5 years in prison. It was here that Porter began writing and publishing his original short stories in earnest; he also decided upon his future pen name, O. Henry. In 1902 Porter was released and moved to New York City, where he launched a prolific and successful career writing short stories. Until his death in 1910, he published nearly 400 stories and wrote more than a story a week for the *New York World Sunday Magazine*. Among other things, his stories were famous for their so-called “twists in the tale” in which everyday people suddenly found themselves in ironic and unlikely situations.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

Writing in the era of American Realism, O. Henry’s stories often reflected the realities he saw around him. Though the works were of course fictional, the characters themselves were based on the sort of “real” working-class people whom O. Henry encountered in the world, particularly people in New York City. In fact, the title of his first collection, *The Four Million*, riffs on a quote by Ward McAllister, who claims that, with the advent of the census, there are now four million people of interest in New York. In this way, O. Henry’s interest in everyday people can be thought of as a response to the conditions of modernity, conditions which began to reveal the interest and diversity of “regular life.” Though he was a realist, this interest of O. Henry’s reveals him to be an early proponent of one of Modernism’s central ideas—that art should have real, ordinary people as its subject, not just the wealthy or important. Furthermore, it is also possible to see the influence of Porter’s own life in his work, such as his time in prison or his time working as a rancher out West. These experiences seem present not just in his focus on “ordinary” people, but also in his interest in shady, down-and-out characters and the improbable circumstances which

transform their lives. As someone who went from being a prisoner to a successful cosmopolitan fiction writer, O. Henry was certainly more aware than most of the peculiarities and improbabilities of American life.

RELATED LITERARY WORKS

“After Twenty Years” comes out of O. Henry’s first collection of short stories, titled *The Four Million*. This collection features some of O. Henry’s most famous short stories, such as “The Gift of the Magi,” “The Cop and the Anthem,” “The Green Door,” and “Springtime à la Carte.” Like “After Twenty Years,” these stories all feature regular, realistic American characters who find themselves in ironic or improbable circumstances, elevating their lives to near-fantastic status. The stories also often end with twist endings, for which “The Gift of the Magi” is the perfect example. These themes are consistent across most of O. Henry’s many collections, such as in *Whirligigs*, a collection published in 1910. This collection features one of O. Henry’s most famous stories, titled, “The Ransom of Red Chief,” in which two kidnappers ironically pay the father of the boy they kidnapped to take him back from them. Like many of O. Henry’s stories, the reader’s expectation is flipped on its head, revealing how the ordinary can become extraordinary with just a little twist of fate. O. Henry’s contemporary, fellow short story author Kate Chopin, was likewise known for twist endings in such stories as “*Désirée’s Baby*.”

KEY FACTS

- **Full Title:** After Twenty Years
- **When Written:** 1906
- **Where Written:** New York
- **When Published:** 1906
- **Literary Period:** Realism
- **Genre:** Short Story, Mystery
- **Setting:** New York City
- **Climax:** Bob is arrested and discovers that the police officer was his old friend, Jimmy Wells.
- **Point of View:** Third Person

EXTRA CREDIT

Romantic Novelization. In 1907, after his first wife’s death, O. Henry married his childhood sweetheart, Sarah Lindsey Coleman. Also a fiction writer, she wrote a fictionalized account of their relationship in her novella, *Wind of Destiny*.

Prison Perk. Despite O. Henry’s time in prison, there is no

record that he ever actually had to stay in a cell. As a licensed pharmacist, he was given opportunity to work in the prison hospital and was thus given a room in the hospital wing.



PLOT SUMMARY

Jimmy Wells and Bob are childhood best friends from New York City. Though they were like brothers in their youth, they gradually fell out of contact with one another. While Jimmy remained in New York, Bob moved out West to pursue his fortune. Before parting ways, however, the two of them agreed to meet 20 years later at **Big Joe Brady's Restaurant**, the place where they last saw one another.

After 20 years, Bob is waiting for Jimmy at the restaurant when a police officer sees him lurking in a dark doorway. The police officer approaches Bob and Bob reassures him that he is only there to meet an old friend. After learning a bit about Bob's story and his pact with Jimmy, the patrolman moves on.

Bob continues to wait for Jimmy long past their agreed-upon meeting time, confident that his friend will arrive. Eventually, a man in an overcoat approaches Bob and introduces himself as Jimmy. The two old friends embrace and walk arm in arm, telling each other about their lives. Eventually, however, they walk by a drug store with bright lights, and Bob realizes that the man is not Jimmy. It is too late, though, and the man reveals himself to be an undercover police officer. He arrests Bob, or rather, "Silky Bob," and hands him a note from a police officer named "Patrolman Wells." The note reveals that the officer from earlier in the story was Jimmy, but he couldn't bring himself to arrest Bob, so he sent the plainclothes police officer instead.



CHARACTERS

MAJOR CHARACTERS

Jimmy Wells – Jimmy Wells is a police officer and Bob's best friend from childhood. While Bob decided to move out West to pursue his fortune, Jimmy chose instead to remain in New York, eventually becoming a police officer. He is also no ordinary police officer, but a particularly impressive and respectable one, walking with confidence and swagger and artfully twirling his club. His ability to remain calm while masking his identity to Bob also suggests great emotional and mental intelligence, as well as decades of experience in law enforcement. Despite having just discovered that his old friend is a wanted man, he does not let on about his identity, politely inquiring after his friend's life without seeming too suspicious. Furthermore, despite arresting Bob at the end of the story, Jimmy also shows loyalty and affection for his old friend. Though Bob does not know it at the time, Jimmy does actually show up on time—early, in fact—for their meeting, showing he is every bit as

reliable as Bob says he is. Moreover, out of loyalty to the memory of their relationship, Jimmy also chooses to not arrest Bob himself. Thus, he respects their friendship while still fulfilling his duty as a guardian of the peace.

Bob – Bob, or "Silky Bob," is a wanted criminal from Chicago as well as Jimmy's best friend from childhood. When he was 18, he decided to move out West, leaving Jimmy behind in New York. Out West he became a hustler and a criminal, making his fortune—as evident by his diamond necklace and gold watch—but also becoming an enemy of the law. Unlike Jimmy, who confidently walks his beat in plain sight of everyone, Bob's time as a criminal has made him covert and circumspect, evident in the way he lurks in the shadows. His life as a criminal seems to have affected him physically; he has a white scar and a pale face. Despite all this, he still reveals himself to be a loyal and reliable friend. Like Jimmy, he has come to their meeting on time, and even when Jimmy seems to be late, Bob does not lose any confidence that his friend will arrive. At the end of the story, Bob is arrested by a plainclothes police officer pretending to be Jimmy. Bob is upset when he learns the officer isn't Jimmy, though it is not clear whether he feels betrayed by his friend or whether he is merely shaken by the revelation.

MINOR CHARACTERS

Plainclothes Police Officer – This unnamed police officer pretends to be Jimmy Wells to fool Bob. He ultimately reveals himself to be a police officer, however, and arrests Bob, handing him Jimmy's note.



THEMES

In LitCharts literature guides, each theme gets its own color-coded icon. These icons make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. If you don't have a color printer, you can still use the icons to track themes in black and white.



LOYALTY VS. DUTY

O. Henry's short story, "After Twenty Years," explores the conflict between personal loyalty and professional duty. The story takes place on the night two childhood friends, Jimmy and Bob, had agreed to meet before they parted ways 20 years earlier. Since that time, however, the two friends have become very different people, a fact which challenges their loyalty to one another. In particular, Jimmy's discovery that Bob is a criminal forces him to choose between remaining loyal to his friend or upholding his duty as a police officer. This decision is especially complicated given the nature of their meeting. If he arrests Bob, he is not only betraying a lifelong friend, but he is betraying a friend who has remained loyal to him by traveling over 1000 miles to uphold a

20-year promise. However, letting Bob go free would mean disregarding his responsibility as a police officer and his obligation to serve justice.

In the end, Jimmy decides to arrest Bob, showing his commitment to upholding the moral standards expected of him as a police officer. However, he does not want to be the one to arrest his friend, and so he sends another officer to do it for him. It is left to the reader to decide whether refusing to arrest him personally is a sign of genuine loyalty to Bob, or a sign of disrespect and cowardice. After all, though he is not the one to physically arrest Bob, Jimmy is still responsible for his arrest. As such, “After Twenty Years” illustrates the challenging choices individuals in positions of authority face when balancing their personal values and professional responsibilities. Jimmy’s decision to prioritize duty over loyalty shows the difficult choices people must make and the sacrifices—or perhaps compromises—they must make to serve the greater good.



TIME AND IDENTITY

The short story “After Twenty Years” explores the relationship between time and identity. In fact, the central tension of the story is whether the two

main characters, Jimmy and Bob, once close friends who grew up together in New York, will keep their 20-year-old promise to meet and will pick up their friendship where it left off. However, in the 20 years since they last saw each other, they have taken vastly different paths in life. Having remained in New York his whole life, Jimmy Wells has become a responsible and respected police officer, a fact reflected physically in his “watchful eye” and “stalwart form.” By contrast, in his search for riches out West, Bob has become a criminal. Though he has found success—evident from his diamond-covered scarf pin and handsome watch—he has paid the price for it, as he is now wanted by the law in Chicago. As such, time has transformed two old friends into enemies, though it is not obvious at first. In fact, when they first meet in the promised location it is as though they are strangers. Though Jimmy recognizes Bob, he also recognizes him as the wanted man in Chicago, and so he does treat Bob as a stranger and hides his own identity. Bob, meanwhile, is too focused on telling his own story to register that the police officer is his old friend. However, by the end of the story both friends ultimately realize how much their respective identities have changed, a fact demonstrated by the new names they are given. Jimmy becomes “Patrolman Wells,” while Bob becomes “Silky Bob” (apparently his criminal nickname). In a twist, the friends successfully meet after 20 years, only to discover that they are now different people and can no longer be friends. As such, the story suggests that time can not only change one’s identity, but turn the best of friends into strangers, or even enemies, in the process.



APPEARANCE, CHARACTER, AND MORALS

In “After Twenty Years,” O. Henry uses physical details—from the rainy New York night to brilliant flashes of electric lights—to create atmosphere and even foreshadow elements of the story. Most strikingly, Jimmy and Bob’s appearances clue readers into aspects of their respective characters. For instance, Jimmy’s upright and law-abiding persona is reflected through his “watchful eye,” “stalwart form,” skillful twirling of his club, and confident gait. Thus, not only is he a police officer, but he physically embodies the characteristics of one – he “makes a fine picture of a guardian of the peace.” On the other hand, Bob’s criminal status is mirrored in his pale face, “keen eyes,” and “white scar,” features that hint at a troubled past. Despite his ill-gotten wealth—made evident by his diamond-encrusted scarf pin and watch—Bob does not seem to be doing well physically. His moral depravity seems to have taken physical form, giving him the appearance of an overly wary, sick person. Even before making both men’s identities obvious, then, O. Henry uses physical appearance to signal that each man’s character has developed and degraded in specific ways over the decades. As such, he suggests that while physical appearance can’t reveal everything about a person, it can certainly reflect their moral trajectory.



SYMBOLS

Symbols appear in **teal text** throughout the Summary and Analysis sections of this LitChart.



BIG JOE BRADY’S RESTAURANT

Big Joe Brady’s restaurant symbolizes the relationship between Jimmy and Bob and, more broadly, the way that time can impact a relationship. At least initially, the restaurant seems to represent the past, present, and future of Jimmy and Bob’s friendship, since it is the last place they saw each other as well as the place they promised to see each other next. However, when they arrive there 20 years later, they not only find that the restaurant is gone, but also that they’ve both changed beyond recognition. While Bob has led a life of crime, Jimmy has become a police officer and, accordingly, is forced to arrest his old best friend. Just like the shuttered restaurant, then, their friendship does not truly exist in the present—only in the past.



QUOTES

Note: all page numbers for the quotes below refer to the Dover edition of *The Gift of the Magi and Other Short Stories* published in 1992.

After Twenty Years Quotes

☞ Trying doors as he went, twirling his club with many intricate and artful movements, turning now and then to cast his watchful eye adown the pacific thoroughfare, the officer, with his stalwart form and slight swagger, made a fine picture of a guardian of the peace.

Related Characters: Jimmy Wells

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 21

Explanation and Analysis

Here, Patrolman Wells performs his nightly duties as a police officer, checking houses and twirling his baton. Though he has yet to say anything in the story, his actions here reveal a lot about his personality and character. His fanciful twirling of the baton, for instance, suggests that he is both well-practiced with the tool as well as confident and comfortable in his role as a police officer. Since the reader is told earlier in the story that his “impressiveness” is “habitual” and not for “show,” it seems that his ability with the baton is more of an expression of his proficiency as an officer than a display of hubris. This is confirmed by the narrator’s comment that the patrolman “ma[kes] a fine picture of a guardian of the peace.” Thus, while his actions may come across as performative, they are just unconscious reflections of his high level of vocational competence. His swagger, in other words, arises naturally out of his professionalism.

☞ As the policeman walked up to him the man spoke up quickly.
“It’s alright, officer,” he said reassuringly. “I’m just waiting for a friend. It’s an appointment I made twenty years ago.”

Related Characters: Bob (speaker), Jimmy Wells

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 21

Explanation and Analysis

This is the first exchange between Bob and Jimmy in the story, though neither character knows the other’s identity yet. As far as the two of them are concerned, one of them is a police officer and the other one is a man lurking in a shadowy doorway late at night. This power dynamic is

reflected in Bob’s nervous attempt to dissuade the patrolman of any suspicion. He realizes that he comes across as a shady character and speaks up “quickly” to explain himself. This moment also hints to the reader that Bob may have something to be nervous about with law enforcement, though it is not revealed until the end of the story that he is in fact a criminal.

This scene is also the height of cosmic irony in the story. Though neither realizes it at first, the two old friends have succeeded here in reuniting at the time and place they promised 20 years earlier. Because both have changed over the years, however, they fail to recognize each other, especially Bob, who seems unable to consider the possibility that his old friend Jimmy might have become a police officer.

☞ We figured that in twenty years each of us ought to have our destiny worked out and our fortunes made, whatever they were going to be.

Related Characters: Bob (speaker), Jimmy Wells

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 21

Explanation and Analysis

Here, Bob explains to the Patrolman why he and Jimmy had agreed to meet 20 years later. Given the opposite paths that the two old friends take in the story, however, this quote takes on somewhat of a tragically ironic significance. Given that Bob has become a wanted criminal in Chicago and Jimmy has become a police officer in New York, in other words, they seem to have chosen destinies which are inherently antagonistic; despite Bob’s innocent optimism (he does not yet realize Jimmy is the patrolman), it does not seem possible for them to meaningfully reunite with one another without there being conflict. As such, the two seem to have chosen paths which are both antagonistic and intertwined. This turns out to be true, as Jimmy is ultimately forced to arrest Bob in order to uphold his integrity as a police officer. All in all, this passage highlights the central tragedy of the story— that people change over time, and that sometimes one must accept that an old friend is just that: a past friend.

☞ But I know Jimmy will meet me here if he's alive, for he always was the truest staunchest chap in the world. He'll never forget. I came a thousand miles to stand in this door to-night, and it's worth it if my old partner shows up.

Related Characters: Bob (speaker), Jimmy Wells

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 22

Explanation and Analysis

Here, Bob expresses his confidence in the reliability of his old friend Jimmy. He extols his virtues and seems to have no doubt that Jimmy will show up to meet him. Given that Jimmy is actually the Patrolman and is thus already there, however, this claim takes on a simultaneously comedic and tragic significance. On the comedic side of things, it is funny for Bob to be expressing his confidence that his old friend will show up... to that very friend. Unbeknownst to Bob, however, Jimmy has already fulfilled his commitment, confirming Bob's confidence that Jimmy will arrive without him even realizing it. Given Bob's eventual arrest, however, Bob's words also assume a certain tragic quality, as it becomes clear that Bob may have mislaid his trust in Jimmy. This difference in loyalty between the two of them is further highlighted by the fact that Bob has traveled a thousand miles to be there, despite the risks to his own freedom and wellbeing. Given Bob's status as a wanted man, his choice to travel to New York to meet Jimmy is an impressive show of loyalty on his part which contrasts with Jimmy's choice to arrest him.

☞ You bet! I hope Jimmy has done half as well. He was a good kind of plodder, though, good fellow as he was. A man gets in a groove in New York. It takes the West to put a razor-edge on him.

Related Characters: Bob (speaker), Jimmy Wells

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 22

Explanation and Analysis

In response to the Patrolman's questions, Bob inadvertently reveals more about his questionable past. Not only has he done well, but the circumstances in which he has done so seem to have hardened him, or rather, made him into someone with a "razor-edge" on him. Combined with his

ostentatious accessories like his diamond-encrusted watch, this comment suggests to the reader that Bob may not exactly be an upstanding citizen and that his sources of wealth are likely shady at best.

As such, this quote also foreshadows the twist at the end of the story which results in Bob's arrest. In particular, it suggests that Jimmy is a more upstanding character than his childhood friend, Bob, and that his choice of career might have taken a similar path. Just as Bob's adventurousness led him down a path of criminality, in other words, Jimmy's being a "plodder," or someone who sticks to what's expected, may have led him down a more virtuous path. Ultimately, this turns out to be true, not only suggesting that people can change over time, but that they often change in ways which exaggerate their dispositions when they were younger.

☞ "You're not Jimmy Wells," he snapped. "Twenty years is a long time, but not long enough to change a man's nose from a Roman to a pug."

"It sometimes changes a good man into a bad one," said the tall man. "You've been under arrest for ten minutes."

Related Characters: Bob, Plainclothes Police Officer (speaker), Jimmy Wells

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 23

Explanation and Analysis

Having just seen his supposed friend in full light, Bob realizes that the man walking beside him is not actually Jimmy. In explanation, he points out that time can only change your appearance so much, to which the man retorts that it can change a "good man into a bad one." This is one of the key themes of the story—the idea that time can change the sort of person you are. In fact, it is arguably Bob's failure to recognize this that leads to his arrest: even though he himself has changed, he is unable to recognize that Jimmy might have changed just as much. Bob is too focused on the appearance of things—like Jimmy's law enforcement outfit or his own flashy accessories—to recognize what is actually in front of him. As such, this scene not only verbalizes one of the story's main themes, but also points out Bob's major shortcoming: his superficial, egotistical interest in the world around him. Had he taken a second to let his supposed friend talk, for instance, he might have realized that the man

was not Jimmy earlier. Similarly, had he considered the possibility that Jimmy might have changed, he might have recognized his friend under the uniform. He does neither of these things, however, and thus misses several opportunities to get out of a sticky situation. Thus, this scene suggests that, while Jimmy is the one who calls in the arrest, Bob is in part responsible for this outcome.

●● His hand was steady when he began to read, but it trembled a little by the time he had finished.

Related Characters: Jimmy Wells, Bob, Plainclothes Police Officer

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 23

Explanation and Analysis

Having just been arrested by the plainclothes police officer, Bob receives a note which reveals that the Patrolman from earlier was his old friend Jimmy. His reaction to this revelation—his “trembling” hand—leaves a lot up for interpretation, as it is hard to know what exactly Bob is feeling in this moment. Not only has he just been arrested, but he has been betrayed by one of his oldest, most trusted friends. As such, his trembling hand could just as easily be a product of anger as it could be of sadness for the end of their relationship. It could also be frustration or annoyance that Jimmy was not willing to arrest him himself, or even disappointment that Jimmy chose not to reveal himself earlier. Thus, this scene highlights the complexity of the emotional dynamic between Bob and Jimmy, leaving the reader equally confused about the state of these two friends’ relationship. Though all the facts are laid out in plain

sight, the author leaves their ultimate interpretation up to the reader.

●● Bob: I was at the appointed place on time. When you struck the match to light your cigar I saw it was the face of the man wanted in Chicago. Somehow I couldn’t do it myself, so I went around and got a plain clothes man to do the job.

Related Characters: Bob (speaker), Jimmy Wells, Plainclothes Police Officer

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 23

Explanation and Analysis

Here, Jimmy reveals to Bob that he was the patrolman from earlier. Instead of telling him in person, however, Jimmy chooses to write Bob a note instead, explaining that it was he who called in the arrest. Jimmy’s motivations for this are not immediately obvious, though it seems most likely that he did not want to spoil the memory of his relationship with Bob by personally arresting him and revealing himself. It is also possible that Jimmy would not have been able to do it at all, had he been there himself. In either case, this note complicates the nature of Jimmy’s loyalty to Bob, since it is legible both as a sign of respect for their relationship as well as the ultimate affront to their relationship—that is, that he was unwilling to respect Bob enough to arrest him himself. Of course, the fact that he is willing to arrest Bob in the first place suggests that, for Jimmy, loyalty to one’s occupation comes before loyalty to a friend, a priority that seems less true of Bob, given his willingness to travel a thousand miles to New York as a wanted man.



SUMMARY AND ANALYSIS

The color-coded icons under each analysis entry make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. Each icon corresponds to one of the themes explained in the Themes section of this LitChart.

AFTER TWENTY YEARS

A policeman patrols his street at 10 o'clock at night. He walks confidently, but it is clearly not for show, as there is no one on the street. The policeman twirls his club with skill and dexterity as he checks on houses. Most places are closed, however, as the street is mostly comprised of stores and businesses. The policeman slows down as he notices a man in the shadows of a hardware store's doorway. The stranger has an unlit cigar in his mouth, and the policeman walks up to him. The man reassures the officer that he has a legitimate reason to be waiting there. He explains that he made an appointment 20 years ago to meet someone at that spot, which used to be called **Big Joe Brady's Restaurant**.

The policeman says that the restaurant was torn down five years before. The man lights his cigar, highlighting his pale face, a square jaw, intelligent eyes, and white scar. He explains that 20 years ago he dined at **Big Joe Brady's** with an old friend, Jimmy Wells, who he had grown up with. They were raised together in New York, but they parted ways because he wanted to travel West whereas Jimmy wanted to remain in New York. That night they agreed to meet at the same location 20 years later and catch up on each other's lives.

The policeman appreciates the story and asks if they have corresponded since. The man explains that they did for a few years, but then eventually they stopped. He assumes some fault for it, explaining that the West was a big and distracting place, and he was always hustling about. Despite this, the man claims that Jimmy will meet him here because he is the truest and most loyal man in the world. The man has traveled over a thousand miles to get here, but he says that if Jimmy comes it will all have been worth it. The policeman asks whether the man did well out West, and the man says yes, claiming that the West makes you sharp. The policeman wishes him luck and goes on his way.

The opening scene introduces two characters who seem to be, if not exactly opposites, from very different walks of life. Though neither speaks, each man's behavior and dress hints at their respective personalities. Based on his confident gait, uniform, and prowess with his baton, for instance, the police officer appears to be a particularly competent, dutiful, and responsible figure. The stranger in the doorway, by contrast, with his unlit cigarette and conspicuous attempt to hide in the shadows of a doorway on an empty street, comes across as a suspicious and shady figure. Unlike the police officer, the man in the doorway wants to remain unseen. This contrast foreshadows a revelation later in the story.



Having lit his cigar, the stranger in the doorway reveals himself to have features which are often associated with shady or suspicious men. For instance, his white scar suggests a violent, malignant past. Despite his appearance, however, the story the man tells about why he is there suggests that he is a loyal friend, having faithfully traveled many miles to be at Big Joe Brady's restaurant 20 years later. This revelation complicates Joe as a character, as it is unclear what sort of person he really is.



As the policeman continues to ask about the man's story, the man reveals himself to be an increasingly complex character. While details like his various references to "hustling" out West further suggest a shady past, his display of commitment to his friend paints him in a positive light. While he may not be the most upright individual, the man seems to genuinely care for and trust his friend Jimmy.



The man smokes in the doorway as he waits for his friend to arrive. He is uncertain whether Jimmy will arrive, but after 20 minutes a tall man shows up. The man asks if it's Bob, and Bob asks if he's Jimmy. They confirm who they are, and Jimmy expresses his sadness that the old restaurant is gone. Bob comments on how much Jimmy has grown. Jimmy suggests that they walk to a place he knows to reminisce about when they were younger. They walk arm and arm down the street, and Bob egotistically tells Jimmy about his time out West.

With the policeman gone, the man in the doorway begins to doubt whether his old friend will really arrive. Though he clearly has a lot of faith in his old friend, it is now far past their agreed-upon meeting time, building suspense for the reader. Still, the man waits it out, showing again the level of commitment he has to Jimmy and their relationship. Though they may have fallen out of contact, it is clear that Jimmy still holds a special place in the man's heart, and he is willing to give him the benefit of the doubt. Though all seems well once Jimmy arrives, the man does notice that his old friend is taller than he remembered him being. This, combined with the lateness of his supposedly "reliable" friend, suggests that everything may not be as well as it seems.



The two men walk under bright lights at the drug store and look at each other. Bob stops and lets go of Jimmy's arm, telling him that he knows he's not actually Jimmy, even after 20 years. The tall man comments on how time can turn people bad, and then says that he, Silky Bob, is under arrest. He says that Chicago wired them Bob might be in town. Bob goes with the plainclothes police officer quietly, and as he does the tall man gives him a note from Patrolman Wells.

Here, Bob realizes that the man he is walking with is not actually his old friend, Jimmy, but a police officer in disguise. Suddenly, the warning signs from before make sense: the man is taller than Bob remembers his old friend being because he is not actually Jimmy. Bob's own past is also revealed, confirming the various clues from earlier in the story which suggested he was a crook or criminal. As the plainclothes police officer reveals, Bob is in fact a wanted criminal, and the officer was only posing as Jimmy to get into his confidence.



Bob unfolds the note and begins to read it. His hand is steady at first, but as he reads the note it begins to tremble. The note is from his old friend Jimmy Wells, who reveals himself as the policeman from earlier. He says that he was at the restaurant on time but recognized Bob as the wanted man from Chicago. He explains that he could not get himself to arrest Bob himself, so he sent another police officer to do it for him.

The note handed to Bob by the plainclothes officer provides the last piece of the story's puzzle. Written by Jimmy (or Patrolman) Wells, it reveals that the police officer from earlier in the story was in fact Bob's old friend, Jimmy, but that he did not reveal himself because he recognized Bob as a criminal. Instead of arresting Bob himself, however, he sent a plainclothes police officer in his stead. As such, Jimmy puts his duty as a protector of the law over his loyalty to his old friend, Bob. Still, his inability to arrest Bob himself shows that Jimmy cannot entirely shake the loyalty he feels toward his friend. Though he is responsible for the arrest, he does not want to tarnish the memory of their relationship by arresting him himself. This suggests that, despite the different paths they chose in life, both men still care about their childhood relationship. Like the former Big Joe Brady's restaurant, however, it is only the memory of their friendship that ultimately remains.





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